

SCIENCE OF READING REVIEW: ARKANSAS PROFESSIONAL EDUCATOR PATHWAY (ArPEP)

ALTERNATIVE ROUTE

On-Site Review: Not reported

WHAT'S IN THIS REPORT?

This report uses evidence from an on-site review to examine how an educator preparation program prepares candidates to teach reading using scientific reading instruction, as Arkansas requires of every approved program. It is meant to inform a continuous improvement process that takes educator preparation programs closer to the goals needed to serve Arkansas's students.

The on-site reviews are carried out by Teacher Prep Inspection-US (TPI-US), an external review organization. TPI-US teams inspect coursework and course materials, observe instruction and clinical practice, review program data, and hold focus groups with candidates, faculty, mentor teachers, and school partners. Division of Elementary and Secondary Education staff participate in the review.

TPI-US rates the program in the three review areas of the Arkansas Literacy Review Framework:

- Review Area 1, "Quality of Literacy Coursework," is rated from course materials, syllabi, assignments, and observations of instruction.
- Review Area 2, "Quality of Field-Based Experiences," is rated from placement records, observation and feedback evidence, and focus groups with candidates, mentor teachers, faculty, and school partners.
- Review Area 3, "Quality of Performance Management and Continuous Improvement," is rated from program data systems, quality-control checkpoints, monitoring practice, and partnership evidence.

Every review area receives a rating. Depending on the framework version, the report may also rate each criterion; some earlier reports discuss every criterion without stating a separate rating for it. Performance Levels are defined as follows, in language drawn from the Arkansas Literacy Review Framework:

PERFORMANCE LEVEL	WHAT THE RATING MEANS
4 — EXCEEDS	Coursework and training CONSISTENTLY address the characteristics of high-quality instruction.
3 — MEETS	Coursework and training USUALLY address the characteristics of high-quality instruction.
2 — APPROACHING	Coursework and training INCONSISTENTLY address the characteristics of high-quality instruction.
1 — BELOW	Coursework and training RARELY OR DO NOT address the characteristics of high-quality instruction.

ARKANSAS PROFESSIONAL EDUCATOR PATHWAY (ArPEP)

ALTERNATIVE ROUTE

REVIEW AREA PERFORMANCE LEVELS		
REVIEW AREA 1 LITERACY COURSEWORK	REVIEW AREA 2 FIELD-BASED EXPERIENCES	REVIEW AREA 3 PERFORMANCE MANAGEMENT
APPROACHING	APPROACHING	BELOW
CRITERIA REVIEWED		
9	11	7
CORRECTIVE ACTION STATUS		
Corrective action plan in place for this review cycle. This program is carrying out a corrective action plan with the Division covering fifteen actions.		

PROGRAM INFORMATION

INSTITUTION NAME	Arkansas Professional Educator Pathway (ArPEP)
LOCATION	Arkansas
PROGRAM REVIEWED	The elementary education pathway of the Arkansas Professional Educator Pathway, a two-year, work-based alternative certification program administered by the Division of Elementary and Secondary Education across 15 sites statewide
PATHWAY	Alternative Route
REVIEW FRAMEWORK	TPI-US Arkansas SOR Review Framework (2024)
REVIEWING BODY	Teacher Prep Inspection-US (TPI-US)
SITE VISIT DATES	Not reported

REVIEW AREA 1: QUALITY OF LITERACY COURSEWORK

REVIEW AREA 1 PERFORMANCE LEVEL	
APPROACHING 9 criteria reviewed	
CRITERION PERFORMANCE LEVELS	
Overview of the science of reading	Approaching
Concepts of print instruction	Below
Collaborative communication, oral language instruction	Approaching
Phonological and phonemic awareness instruction	Approaching
Phonics, orthography, automatic word recognition instruction	Approaching
Fluency instruction	Approaching
Vocabulary instruction	Approaching
Text comprehension instruction	Approaching
Writing instruction	Below
WHAT THE REVIEWERS FOUND	
Reviewers examined the RISE K-2 Days 1-6 and RISE 3-6 Days 1-6 trainings, the science of reading modules, the K-2 and 3-6 small group and effective Tier One modules, Sounds Walls, and the K-2 writing modules, and they interviewed course content developers. Seven of the nine criteria were approaching and two were below. Reviewers found the RISE curriculum grounded in science of reading frameworks, with candidates studying Scarborough's Rope, the Simple View of Reading, the Four-Part Processing Model, and Ehri's phases of word reading development across each day of the six-day training. Practice was largely confined to short scenarios embedded in presentation slides and was not extended through peer-to-peer teaching, structured debriefs, or classroom application. Concepts of print instruction scored below because the six days of RISE training did not explicitly address it. Writing instruction scored below because the writing modules are optional rather than required and include no peer teaching, structured assessment, or field-based application.	
REVIEW RECOMMENDATIONS	
• Strengthen coursework to clinical connections by requiring candidates to carry out assignments tied to the RISE modules in their own classrooms, and monitor that application through a structured observation tool and a lesson plan review process with targeted feedback • Integrate assessment opportunities throughout the science of reading modules, supplementing each day of RISE training with an overview of the formal and informal assessments associated with each literacy component and requiring candidates to assess a small group of students and analyze the results	
CORRECTIVE ACTIONS TARGETING THIS AREA	
Three of the fifteen corrective actions target this review area.	

REVIEW AREA 2: QUALITY OF FIELD-BASED EXPERIENCES

REVIEW AREA 2 PERFORMANCE LEVEL	
APPROACHING 11 criteria reviewed	
CRITERION PERFORMANCE LEVELS	
Selection of clinical placement schools	Below
Selection of cooperating teachers (mentor teachers)	Below
Opportunities to observe models of effective early literacy practice	Approaching
Field-based placements provide opportunities to use HQIM	Approaching
Responsibilities build to candidate readiness for full responsibility	Below
Opportunities to apply learning about multilingual children	Below
Opportunities to apply learning about students who experience difficulty reading	Below
Mentor teachers are skillful and can coach candidates	Approaching
Faculty and supervisors guide and evaluate candidates through training	Below
Quality of written and oral feedback	Approaching
Student engagement and candidate impact on student learning	Approaching
WHAT THE REVIEWERS FOUND	
Reviewers observed one planned candidate observation and feedback session and a video submission of literacy lessons taught for the Educative Teaching Performance Assessment, evaluated written feedback across various forms, and interviewed site facilitators, principals, human resource departments, mentor teachers, program completers, and current candidates. Six of the eleven criteria were below and five were approaching. The program does not verify whether the schools where candidates accept employment use high-impact teaching practices or serve diverse student populations, and principals reported no communication from ArPEP about mentor selection criteria. ArPEP operates across 15 sites and could not identify which literacy HQIM each placement location uses. Candidates enter teaching roles in the second year, and site facilitators and principals reported that many new teachers focus on classroom management rather than the summer literacy coursework. The program provides no training for program supervisors or supervising practitioners, and written and oral feedback varied widely in format and quality.	
REVIEW RECOMMENDATIONS	
- Identify and implement a guided literacy observation tool used consistently by program supervisors across all sites, pilot it with site facilitators on a recorded lesson, provide annual training with calibration procedures for inter-rater reliability, and require at least two formal literacy observations each semester - Establish clear, evidence-based criteria for selecting placement schools and mentor teachers, together with a formal agreement to share with partner schools that outlines shared responsibilities for supporting candidate learning and sets expectations for candidate performance	
CORRECTIVE ACTIONS TARGETING THIS AREA	
Nine of the fifteen corrective actions target this review area.	

REVIEW AREA 3: QUALITY OF PERFORMANCE MANAGEMENT AND CONTINUOUS IMPROVEMENT

REVIEW AREA 3 PERFORMANCE LEVEL	
BELOW 7 criteria reviewed	
CRITERION PERFORMANCE LEVELS	
Quality of data the program collects and uses	Below
Internal quality control gates (or checkpoints) and intervention plans	Below
Quality of monitoring	Below
Monitoring coursework quality, teaching quality, and clinical connections	Below
Quality improvement planning	Below
Partnerships improve candidate experiences with HQIM	Below
Evaluation of partnerships for readiness to teach early literacy	Below
WHAT THE REVIEWERS FOUND	
Reviewers examined the data ArPEP collects, its internal quality control practices, its monitoring and improvement planning, and its partnerships with the districts and schools that employ its candidates, drawing on documents submitted across all three domains and on interviews with site facilitators, principals, and human resource departments. All seven criteria were rated below. ArPEP collects Foundations of Reading scores and edTPA results and does not require sites to collect or report additional internal data, and it acknowledged that site renewal decisions are not tied to data. The program lacks formal checkpoints and intervention procedures for candidates who struggle, and it has no system for monitoring coursework quality, coursework teaching quality, or coursework clinical connections. Improvement planning is not a consistent or required practice across the 15 sites. No formal partnerships or memoranda of understanding exist with participating districts, and principals reported limited communication with the program.	
REVIEW RECOMMENDATIONS	
- Identify the specific quantitative and qualitative data to collect from each site, including literacy-specific observations and written feedback, field-based literacy assignments, stakeholder survey data, and K-12 student work samples, and analyze those data at the candidate level, the site level, and across all ArPEP programs - Establish a sustained cycle of data monitoring that triangulates multiple sources of evidence and includes system-wide data review sessions at least twice each academic year, with improvement planning recorded as specific measurable action steps that are revisited monthly - Establish a team to oversee data collection, quality, and analysis, and train all site facilitators and supervisors on consistent use of the tools, on data submission procedures, and on confidentiality requirements	
CORRECTIVE ACTIONS TARGETING THIS AREA	
Five of the fifteen corrective actions target this review area.	

CORRECTIVE ACTION

Where a review identifies findings that require follow-up, the program develops a corrective action plan with the Division of Elementary and Secondary Education. The recommendations under each review area above are the reviewers' advice; the plan below is the program's formal response, monitored by the Division. Actions are grouped by the review area whose findings prompted them.

TOTAL ACTIONS	HIGH PRIORITY	MEDIUM PRIORITY	LOW PRIORITY
15	12	3	0

The plan sets out 15 corrective actions: 12 high priority and 3 medium priority. The priorities are the plan's own. Some actions target more than one review area, so the per-area counts shown under each review area add to more than the total.

ACTIONS THE PROGRAM IS TAKING

PRIORITY	ACTION	FINDING THAT REQUIRED IT	SUCCESS METRICS
HIGH RA1	Course Revisions (required writing modules); Model Lesson Library; Lesson Internalization Training	Writing instruction below; optional professional development, not required for all candidates; lack peer-to-peer teaching, structured assessment, and field-based application.	100% of candidates complete required writing coursework; 100% deliver ≥ 1 coached writing lesson with student work samples; ≥85% proficient on the writing rubric
HIGH RA1	Course Revisions (concepts of print module); Kindergarten Screening Practicum Task	Concepts of print below; training did not explicitly address concepts of print.	100% of candidates complete the concepts-of-print module; 100% participate in a kindergarten screening and design a print-concepts reading experience; ≥85% proficient on the associated rubric
HIGH RA2, RA3	School Selection Rubric; MOU Revision with HQIM/SOR Criteria; Partner Placement Targets	Selection of clinical placement schools below; HQIM partnerships and partnership evaluation both Below; does not verify if employing schools use high impact practices, show K–12 growth, or serve diverse populations; no formal MOUs exist; principals report limited communication	Selection rubric adopted and applied to 100% of placements; MOUs executed with 100% of participating districts; recommended schools list published; partner scorecard ≥3/4
HIGH RA2	Mentor Selection Criteria; Mentor PD (RISE/HQIM); Mentor Verification Process	Selection of cooperating teachers below; mentor teachers skillful Approaching; principals independently identify mentors; practices vary across sites; some sites have a literacy expert or coach.	100% of mentors meet published criteria with a signed verification on file; ≥90% of mentors complete mentor PD; 15 of 15 sites have a qualified literacy coach or mentor
HIGH RA2	Pre-Practicum Sequence Design; Peer Microteaching; Guided Practice Blocks	Pre- and practicum responsibilities below; coursework delivered in the prior summer or concurrently; more focused on classroom management than literacy coursework.	100% of candidates complete the full pre-practicum sequence before assuming full classroom responsibility; ≥85% proficient on the readiness rubric at sequence exit; documented feedback on every experience
HIGH RA2	Inclusive Practices (ML); Virtual/Sim Simulations; Partner Placement Targets	Multilingual learner opportunities below; does not ensure coursework or field experiences for multilingual learners' literacy development; placements occur by chance.	100% of candidates complete the ML module; ≥ 1 ML placement or simulation for 100% of candidates; 100% of literacy lesson plans include language objectives

PRIORITY	ACTION	FINDING THAT REQUIRED IT	SUCCESS METRICS
HIGH RA2	Tiered Supports Module; Dyslexia Practices; Data Informed Differentiation Training	Preparation for students who experience difficulty reading below; curriculum focuses on core instruction with limited content on evidence-based practices for diverse or struggling readers; observed lessons reflected minimal differentiation or targeted intervention.	100% of candidates complete the tiered supports module; 100% submit a data informed differentiated lesson cycle; ≥85% of observed lessons show targeted small group or Tier 2 support
HIGH RA2, RA3	Standardized Observation Tool; Calibration & Reliability Training; Feedback Protocol	Supervisor and practitioner training below; quality of written and oral feedback approaching; quality of monitoring below; no training to support supervisors or practitioners in applying consistent standards; written and oral feedback varies.	Single tool adopted at 15 of 15 sites; 100% of observers trained and certified; interrater agreement ≥0.80; ≥2 formal observations per candidate per semester; 100% of feedback records name student learning impact and actionable next steps
HIGH RA3	Program Data Dashboard; Key Assessments; Data Governance Team	Quality of data below; quality of monitoring below; monitoring of coursework quality below; monitors Foundations of Reading and edTPA results.	Data governance team seated; defined indicator set collected at 15 of 15 sites; dashboard live; 2 system-wide reviews per year with documented action steps; ≥80% of action items completed
HIGH RA3	Quality Control Gate Design; Intervention Plan Template; Support Meeting Protocol	Internal quality control gates below; lack formal checkpoints and internal quality control mechanisms.	Gates defined and applied to 100% of candidates; 100% of candidates not meeting a gate receive a documented support plan within 10 instructional days; documented progress review at each check in
HIGH RA3	Improvement Planning Protocol; Site Renewal Criteria; Standardized Templates	Quality improvement planning below; partnership evaluation below; grant application with limited criteria; improvement planning not consistent or required; sites not systematically examining effectiveness.	100% of sites submit a data-driven improvement plan annually; renewal decisions for 100% of sites cite candidate performance evidence; standardized templates in use at 15 of 15 sites
HIGH RA1	Module Assignments; Assessment Practice Cycles; Observation Tool Integration	Overview of SOR, oral language, phonological and phonemic awareness, phonics and orthography, fluency, vocabulary, and text comprehension all approaching; opportunities confined to short scenarios; no peer-to-peer teaching, structured debriefs, or classroom application; use assessment data in any component limited.	100% of RISE days carry a required application assignment; 100% of candidates complete an assessment administration and analysis cycle per component; ≥1 supervisor observation per component; ≥85% proficient on component rubrics
MEDIUM RA2	Model Lesson Library; Site Observation Requirement; Virtual/Video Observation	Opportunities to observe models Approaching; some provide observation of effective PK–3 literacy practice across grade levels, but ensuring these opportunities exist not consistent.	100% of candidates complete ≥1 PK–3 observation of high-quality literacy instruction; model lesson library live with coverage of each literacy component; 15 of 15 sites report compliance
MEDIUM RA2	HQIM Placement Verification; Partner Placement Targets	HQIM use in field placements Approaching; could not identify which literacy HQIM each placement location uses.	HQIM in use documented for 100% of placement locations; ≥90% of placements in HQIM implementing classrooms; HQIM coverage reported by site each semester
MEDIUM RA2	Engagement Routines Coaching; Data Informed Lesson Planning; Observation Tool Look-Fors	Student engagement and candidate impact on student learning approaching; Performance was notably inconsistent: some facilitate high engagement through choral response and active questioning, others showed uneven engagement with limited opportunity to demonstrate learning; lesson differentiation limited.	100% of literacy lesson plans include differentiation grounded in assessment data; ≥80% of observed lessons show sustained engagement and evidence of differentiation; look for scores improve term over term

OVERSIGHT

Each action in the plan carries an evidence requirement and a rationale tied to a review finding. The plan leaves the responsible owner and the completion timeline for program leadership to assign, so those entries are not recorded in the plan as issued and are not published here. Review area assignments in the table were made by matching each action's stated rationale to the review area whose findings it answers.

Sources: TPI-US Arkansas Literacy Review, Arkansas Professional Educator Pathway (ArPEP), conducted under the TPI-US Arkansas SOR Review Framework (2024). Rating scale language quoted from the Arkansas Literacy Review Framework.